Chapter 4: The Taj Mahal in Modern Times

After its creation, the Taj Mahal functioned within the Mughal Empire much as it had been intended: a symbol of imperial power along the Yumana River maintained by donations from the government and income from the attached bazaar and caravansary. While it was seen as having historic relevance, it was not seen through the eyes of nostalgia as belonging to a past time, in the same way that the monuments of Washington D.C. are seen as historically valuable by Americans today but are also considered part of the everyday modern symbolic life of the nation, not representing a deceased people, regime or belief system. For the Taj Mahal, however, this began to change as the Mughal government crumbled and other states began to rise up in India to replace it, particularly the British Raj.

In fact, the Taj gained its first protection as a site with a valuable history during the British colonial period, thanks to a group led by famed British Orientalist Sir William Jones, who established the Asiatic Society in 1784 in Calcutta, at that time the capital of British India. During this period, the Mughal Empire had crumbled down to a rump state based around Delhi, and Agra itself was administered by the powerful Maratha state based out of today's Maharastra. By the early 19th century, British power had been expanded to include Agra, Delhi and the Yamuna Valley, and soon after those conquests, the Society appointed Francis Buchanan to survey the monuments of the new territories, including the Taj. The British administration even gave monies to maintain the Taj, one of the very few monuments they financed, perhaps because during this time, it became increasingly popular with British visitors who began to see it as a symbol of romantic love. The famous British writer Rudyard Kipling, a champion of imperialism who wrote at length about British India, described it as “the embodiment of all things pure.”